



CIVIC GRANTS COMMISSION MEETING MINUTES

May 21, 2026

1. Call to order/Roll Call.

The meeting was called to order at 5:30 p.m. Members present: Dave Kieck, Melissa Ellis, Aleta Schilling, Ericka Lang. Ald David Bartoshevich arrived at 6:20 p.m., left at 6:30 p.m. and arrived at 6:42 p.m.

2. Approval of March 19, 2026 meeting minutes.

Schilling motioned to approve the minutes, seconded by Ellis. Vote unanimous.

3. Presentations by civic grant applicants.

The commission received six applications. Lang explained to each applicant that the commission is not voting on any applications until after discussing the grant program with the common council, per their request.

APPLICATION SOUTH MILWAUKEE STREET DEPARTMENT. City Engineer Genevieve Stollenwerk applied for the grant to assist with creating a city-wide proactive tree planting program, requesting \$60,000. The funds would be used for professional services to inventory all street trees, update online mapping application, train staff and develop a long-term plan to systematically plant street trees. The city does not have a city-wide program and documentation of a city-wide program was not located. An inventory was completed over a decade ago in response to the Emerald Ash Borer disease that resulted in removal of thousands of street trees. Stollenwerk added that given the enormity of need, capital borrowing is warranted.

Kieck inquired about assistance through college forestry programs and collaborating with adjacent communities that have established forestry departments.

Commissioners noted eligibility given the city intends to fund the project. Stollenwerk noted the city's budget includes tree supply, but not phase one that creates a program.

Commissioners agreed the program meets some eligibility requirements and agreed the recent information that capital funding is involved, disqualifies the application.

APPLICATION POLICE DEPARTMENT. Captain Dan Fournier was present, requesting \$3,500 to create a Ring Doorbell Program, using the funds to purchase the doorbells. The purpose is to improve community safety. Videos have become far more reliable than witnesses. The criteria would limit incomes and possibly in areas that show above average calls, if there is a large demand. The funds would not go toward subscriptions. Police could offer to install and show how to use. Currently, police flag existing addresses if a doorbell camera exists.

Schilling and Kieck suggested they request additional funds as purchasing additional doorbells in following years would not be eligible.

Commissioners agreed the doorbell initiative meets eligibility criteria: as an innovative program addressing an unmet community need and encourages collaboration that strengthens community systems.

APPLICATION GROWING SOUTH MILWAUKEE ART WORKS. Darlene Piszczek and Leah Minue presented. Art Works requests \$15,000.

They request \$10,000 for a short-term professional contract to hire a professional grant writer to train the five-member Art Works board on writing grants and provide resources. A consultant in the area has agreed to provide training. Piszczek added that professional grant writing services are very costly, closer to six figures.

The \$5,000 request is for a short-term contract for marketing services that create a mural tour with QR codes, telling the artist's story.

Commissioners agreed that both items meet eligibility. Both build capacity of Art Works. The mural tour offers an art experience and the grant training provides skills to the board to effect change.

APPLICATION FRIENDS OF SOUTH MILWAUKEE LIBRARY (Friends). Friends president Monica Rodriguez presented their request for \$6,000 to create a Household Tool Lending Library. The funds would be used for purchasing tools, storage equipment and associated supplies. The library has a small area for the Library of Things, that has crochet hoods, Nintendo games, and other items the community can check out. Friends completed a survey of likely items they would want to use and spoke with other libraries that already have these programs. Friends are confident that a tool library will attract community members to the library that don't currently use it.

Ellis inquired about volunteer training, regarding injuries and maintenance. Rodriguez said many people have already expressed interest in assisting with the maintenance of the equipment and training where needed. People would sign a liability form as part of checking out tools.

Commissioners agreed the tool lending program meets eligibility criteria. It addresses an unmet need, encourages collaboration and partnerships, and builds skills.

APPLICATION HUMAN CONCERNS. Human Concerns Board President Dan Rozel presented. They are requesting \$15,000 to hire a marketing professional for a limited term to develop and execute campaigns to promote the nonprofit and improve fundraising. About half the annual revenue comes from the local community. A marketing person would help engage more people in the community and in the media. Human Concerns mails out a letter once a year to fundraise and share their mission and activities and infrequently post on social media. Last year they updated their brochure.

They have about 30 volunteers and are opened to the public 15 hours a week, but operate 40 hours a week.

Lang inquired about past funding through the Bucyrus-Erie company. Rozel stated that the company provided funds annually through an employee-match program. The Bucyrus Foundation matched what employees contributed.

Commissioners agreed this meets eligibility, helping improve operations and organizations impact.

APPLICATION BUCYRUS MUSEUM. A representative from the museum was not in attendance. They applied for a laptop and Microsoft Home Office license to display archived information on Bucyrus employees and numerous other print publications that have been scanned in. The grant request is \$1,880.

Commissioners agreed this is a new service and amenity for museum-goers.

Lang commented that the commission will identify deliverables to include in all agreements. Suggested deliverables were mentioned during each presentation.

4. Update on previous grant recipient projects.

Lang reviewed the status of six approved grant awards from the 2025-2026 cycle.

Friends of South Milwaukee Library, South Milwaukee Historical Society and the South Milwaukee Celebrations Committee completed their projects and submitted financial reports.

Human Concerns provided expenditure documents for most of the funds. Further information was requested and the remaining funds will be spent by the end of May.

MARM Education and Conservation Center spent the majority of the grant and requested an extension to July 31st to complete the solar portion of the Self-Contained Urban Growing Unit/container.

Leah Minue of Growing South Milwaukee provided an update on the community garden shed and requested an extension to June 30th. The concrete pad was recently poured and volunteers are set to install the shed.

5. Discussion of the Bucyrus Civic Grant Program criteria and eligibility requirements.

Summary of commissioner comments regarding program eligible and ineligible requirement.

- Most of the past awarded grants are for projects and not a new or improved programs.
- Program allows local government to apply. It was questioned if a project or program would happen even if a grant was awarded and suggest removing local government as an eligible organization.
- Fixed assets are eligible and most storage equipment is considered a fixed asset. Commissioners previously determined replacing storage equipment is not the intent of the program as it is most often a general operating expense. Commissioners defer to the council to determine if storage should be eligible.
- Hiring professional services should remain an eligible expense as nonprofit budgets limit paid staff.
- The program should not limit how often an organization applies. South Milwaukee has a small number of nonprofits.
- Professional services are essential to improve and grow services. Nonprofits do not have the knowledge and expertise of all aspects for growing and improving operations. Limited-term services should not drive the general fund.
- Application process. The city received a comment from a nonprofit to improve the application process. Commissioners suggest eliminating the initial Letter of Interest phase and merge with application.

6. Adjourn.

Meeting adjourned at 8:13 p.m.

Recorded by,

Ericka Lang, economic development manager